

How to Tie a Bowline Knot

By: Ethan Hershey

Introduction

The bowline (pronounced BOH-lin) is one of the most useful knots you can know. It creates a fixed loop at the end of a rope that does not slip or tighten under load and can be untied easily even after heavy use. Sailors, hikers, and rescue workers all rely on it. These instructions will guide you through three phases: forming the loop, threading the working end, and tightening and checking the knot. The process takes about five minutes to learn and under thirty seconds once you have practiced.

Note: The bowline works best under a steady, sustained load. Do not use it where the rope will be repeatedly jerked or shaken, as this can cause the knot to loosen over time.

Key Terms

Before you begin, familiarize yourself with these terms. As seen in Figure 1, the rope has three sections you will need to identify.

- **Working end:** The short, free end of the rope you manipulate to form the knot.
- **Standing end:** The long end that leads away from the knot toward whatever you are securing.
- **Bight:** A curved section of rope between the two ends.

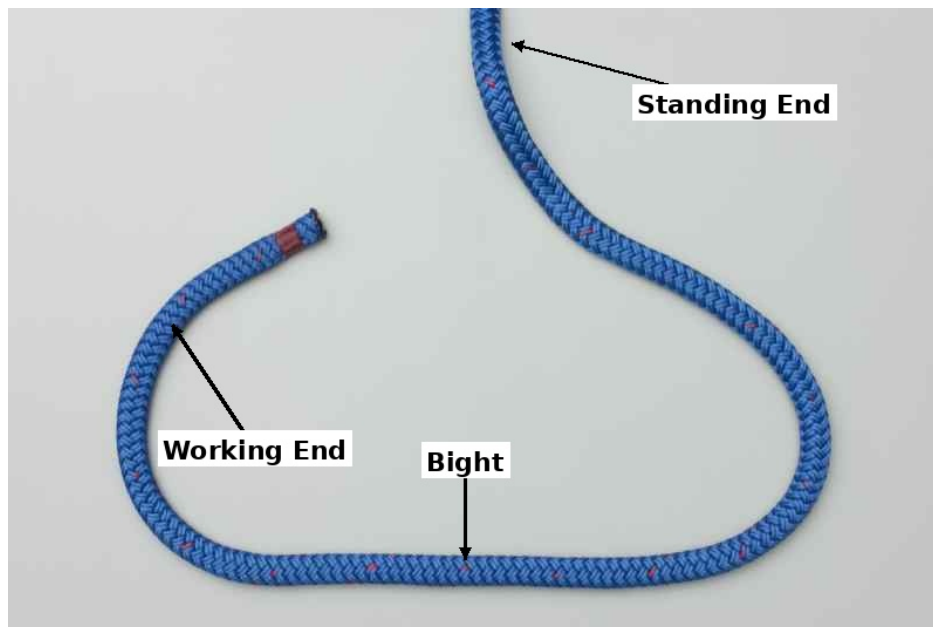


Figure 1: The three parts of the rope: working end, standing end, and bight¹

Materials

- One length of rope, at least three feet long. The recommended diameter is between 1/4 inch and 1/2 inch.

A thicker rope is easier to handle and is the better choice while you are learning.

Caution: Always check that your finished knot is tightened correctly before using it to secure anything. A loose bowline can slip and fail under load.

Phase 1: Forming the Loop

This phase forms the small loop that the rest of the knot is built around. Hold the rope with about twelve inches of working end on the right side.

1. Hold the rope with both hands, leaving about twelve inches of working end on the right side.
2. Pinch the rope with your left hand about eight inches from the working end to mark where the loop will form.
3. Bring the working end up and over the standing end to form a small overhand loop. The working end should cross on top of the standing end and point upward through the loop, as seen in Figure 2.



Figure 2: The overhand loop with the working end on top²

Caution: Make sure the working end crosses over the standing end. If it crosses under, the knot will not hold.

Phase 2: Threading the Working End

This phase threads the working end through the loop to form the body of the knot. Make sure the small loop from Phase 1 is still open before you begin.



Figure 3: The working end threaded up through the loop³

4. Pass the working end up through the small loop from underneath, pushing it toward you. It should now point up out of the loop, as seen in Figure 3.
5. Bring the working end around behind the standing end, moving from right to left.
6. Pass the working end back down through the small loop, pushing it away from you. It should now point downward parallel to the standing end, with a large loop formed on the left.

Phase 3: Tightening and Checking the Knot

This phase tightens and confirms the knot is correctly formed. A properly tightened bowline will have a fixed loop that does not change size when pulled.

7. Hold the large loop in one hand and the standing end in the other. Pull them firmly in opposite directions to tighten the knot.
8. Check that the working end is snug against the knot and is not sticking out more than two inches.
9. Inspect the finished knot, as seen in Figure 4. The loop should not change size when you pull on the standing end or the loop.



Figure 4: The completed and tightened bowline knot⁴

10. Tug firmly on both the loop and the standing end several times to confirm the knot is set.

Note: Your bowline is complete. You can untie it easily by pushing the bight of the knot forward toward the loop.

Troubleshooting

The loop tightens when I pull on the standing end.

The initial loop was formed in the wrong direction. Untie the knot and repeat Phase 1, making sure the working end crosses over the standing end.

The knot falls apart when I tighten it.

The working end was threaded in the wrong direction in step 6. Make sure it passes back down through the small loop away from you. Untie and repeat Phase 2 from step 4.

The working end is too short after tightening.

You did not leave enough rope at the start. Untie the knot and start over, leaving at least twelve inches of working end before forming the loop in Phase 1.

Glossary

Bight: A curved section of rope between the two ends.

Bowline: A knot that forms a fixed, non-slipping loop at the end of a rope.

Standing end: The long end of the rope that leads away from the knot.

Working end: The short, free end of the rope used to form the knot.

Sources

¹ Image from <https://www.animatedknots.com/bowline-knot>

² Image from <https://www.animatedknots.com/bowline-knot>

³ Image from <https://www.animatedknots.com/bowline-knot>

⁴ Image from <https://www.animatedknots.com/bowline-knot>